

Newsom steps up fight for housing

Administration files legal actions against five cities it says aren't meeting benchmarks.

By Grace Toohey

California Gov. Gavin Newsom's administration has threatened five new California cities with legal repercussions for failing to comply with required housing plans as part of the governor's ongoing efforts to ensure that local municipalities meet obligations to increase affordable housing across the state.

The administration's latest legal filings accuse Calexico, Costa Mesa, Half Moon Bay, Ridgecrest and Turlock of missing benchmarks for the latest round of mandated housing planning, as outlined by the state's landmark housing supply law, formally known as the "housing element."

The law, in place since 1969, requires cities and counties every eight years to develop plans to add housing based on a specific allocation that takes into account the region's needs. It's a massive undertaking that is aimed at easing California's ongoing housing crisis but has routinely drawn criticism for undermining local autonomy, requiring difficult parameters — which often include zoning changes — and not always translating to the scale of needed housing.

But given the state's growing need, and now armed with a new law that allows more serious fines for municipalities that fail to comply, Newsom's administration has doubled down on the housing element.

"California can't solve the housing crisis while some cities sit on their hands and dare us to do something about it," Newsom said in a statement about this latest legal action. "These five jurisdictions had every chance to follow the law and plan for their fair share of housing. ... Housing law applies state-wide, and no city gets a pass."

But three of the cities facing the new legal repercussions say they are working to complete the lengthy plans, despite a slow process. Huntington Beach, meanwhile, has been more defiant, refusing for years to zone for thousands of new homes that the housing law had required. Huntington Beach became the poster child for such enforcement

[See Housing, A6]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

ORANGE COUNTY is seeing waves up to 8 feet high at its south-facing beaches. Above, Laguna Beach.

Southland facing a triple threat of heat, humidity and high surf

Temperatures topping 100 in inland areas raise more risk of fire

By Rong-Gong Lin II

Southern California will face a triple threat this week of dangerous heat, muggy weather and, along the coast, hazardous high waves.

"We're looking at an at least several days — if not longer — heat event, which can really be concerning," said meteorologist Robbie Munroe of the National Weather Service's Oxnard office.

From Tuesday through next Monday, temperatures could hit 109 in Paso Robles, 108 in Lancaster, 106 in Canoga Park, 102 in Santa Clarita, 99 in Covina, 92 in downtown Los Angeles and 87 in Long Beach.

Officials warned of elevated fire danger across large swaths of Southern California starting Tuesday, with a high risk of fast-moving and

"plume-dominated" fires driven by heat and instability. Such blazes have large vertical growth and can spread rapidly even when not driven by the wind.

But wind-driven fires will still be a risk — especially for southwestern Santa Barbara County, where expected sundowner winds down the southern slopes of the Santa Ynez Mountains could cause a fire to explode if there's ignition.

What makes this heat wave particularly dangerous will be the lack of cooling overnight. There will be a moderate-to-high risk for heat illness Wednesday through Monday, according to the National Weather Service.

"During the peak of this heat event, we'll also see very warm overnight lows, which just adds to that heat stress," Munroe said.

With overnight temperatures only

dipping to 70 degrees in the San Fernando and Santa Clarita valleys and 69 in Long Beach, he said, "we're not going to see a lot of heat relief."

The conditions are brought on by a powerful ridge of high pressure moving in from the east as well as the unusual path of the remains of Tropical Storm Elida, which is traveling northward in the Pacific Ocean and is sending hazardous surf and strong rip currents to Southern California beaches.

Dangerously high temperatures will also affect the Inland Empire, inland Orange County, the valleys in San Diego County and the deserts and mountains.

Temperatures later this week are expected to exceed 100 degrees in the Inland Empire and in some parts of San Diego County's interior valleys,

[See Weather, A6]

What big start for 'The Odyssey' means

By Samantha Masunaga

It took an ancient Greek epic to ignite a fire at the box office last weekend, as Christopher Nolan's adaptation of "The Odyssey" became one of the biggest movie events of the year.

The film, led by Matt Damon as Odysseus, hauled in \$123.5 million in the U.S. and Canada on its way to a global total of nearly \$264 million.

In many ways, "The Odyssey" is a throwback to old-school Hollywood filmmaking, with Nolan's use of practical effects and numerous on-location shoots. It's

also a sign that audiences will still pack theaters for the right kind of movie.

The Universal Pictures film outperformed studio expectations of a \$117-million domestic premiere and set a record for the highest-grossing opening weekend for a live-action or R-rated film this year. It was also the biggest-ever global opening for one of Nolan's films.

"Audiences always want to be thoroughly immersed in the theatrical experience and engulfed by the story and the production, and Christopher Nolan's 'The Odyssey' is a perfect example of that," Jim Orr, Uni-

versal's president of domestic distribution, said Sunday. "When you have a very substantial opening, and you have those kinds of audience scores, it only points to what should be a remarkable run throughout the summer and into the fall."

That's good news for the summer box office, which lately has seen a bit of ebb and flow.

"The Odyssey" now ranks as the third-largest domestic opening of the year, trailing only kid-friendly films such as Walt Disney Co. and Pixar's "Toy Story 5" and Universal, Illumination and Nintendo's

"The Super Mario Galaxy Movie."

Though family-friendly films have become power players for theaters, the two most recent flicks — Disney's live-action "Moana" and Universal and Illumination's "Minions & Monsters" saw softer openings.

After the big weekend for "The Odyssey," the summer box office is up 7.3% compared with the lackluster 2025 season, according to entertainment data firm Rentrak. More encouraging, the year-to-date domestic box office is now 10.4% higher than for the same period

[See 'Odyssey,' A11]

Overdose or murder? Suits allege cover-up

Two LAPD detectives and a prosecutor claim retaliation for investigating the case.

By Libor Jany

A veteran LAPD narcotics detective is suing the city of L.A., claiming he faced retaliation from supervisors and fellow officers after he refused to stop investigating a young woman's suspicious death.

Alexander Tan alleged in his lawsuit, filed July 7 in Los Angeles County Superior Court, that his unwillingness to go along with a "coordinated cover-up" of the death of 18-year-old Amelia Salehpour led the department to derail a "distinguished" career that included numerous awards and commendations.

In early 2024, Tan and his then-police partner, Det. Jose Verdin, had been conducting an investigation of what police described as a known

"flop house" in Van Nuys when they learned of Salehpour's death there.

Tan claimed in the lawsuit that Salehpour's death was misclassified as an overdose. He alleged that he and his partner found evidence that she had instead been strangled. When the detectives reported their findings up their chain of command, Tan said in the lawsuit, the department retaliated by taking away resources from their investigation, "dis-mantling" their drug enforcement team, and ultimately separating the partners by transferring them to different units.

Verdin has filed a retaliation lawsuit of his own, and the prosecutor who handled the case has filed a government claim, alleging she faced an "increasingly hostile work environment" as the LAPD sought to "silence" her.

The LAPD said it doesn't discuss pending litigation and the city attorney's office, which typically defends the

[See Lawsuit, A8]



BENJAMIN FANJOY Getty Images

LETTUCE INVESTIGATION

FDA will continue to scrutinize Taylor Farms, the produce supplier suspected in cyclosporiasis outbreak, despite a false positive. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

The downfall of a cartel boss

Ismael "El Mayo" Zambada is sent to U.S. prison for life after a violent career, surprise capture. **NATION, A4**

Weather

Mostly sunny; warm. L.A. Basin: 89/69. **B6**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Argentina's ugly exit stains legacy

Soccer team shows lack of class when it brawls with Spain after losing World Cup. **SPORTS, B10**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



7

85944 00200 5

Women in Africa die in U.S. abortion fight

Sweeping restrictions on foreign aid under Trump have deadly consequences.

By Monika Pronczuk and Thalia Beaty

KISUMU, Kenya — As U.S. antiabortion groups' campaign to restrict abortion access at home and abroad has gained strength since President Trump returned to office, his administration is delivering new global momentum to the movement by exporting its view of "family values" to nations overseas.

At the annual March for Life demonstration in January in Washington, Vice President JD Vance announced sweeping new restrictions on U.S. funding for nongovernmental organizations, foreign governments and U.N. agencies that promote access to abortion, gender-affirming care and diversity initiatives over-

seas. "We're going to start blocking every international NGO that performs or promotes abortion abroad from receiving a dollar of U.S. money," he told the crowd.

That effort has been particularly active in Africa, where doctors and advocates now describe an environment of rising harassment, arbitrary detentions and backstreet abortions, with often deadly results for women across the continent.

The expanded restrictions build on the antiabortion advocacy work carried out by conservative U.S. nonprofits abroad — especially in Africa, where healthcare is highly dependent on foreign aid. The region has the world's highest estimated proportion of unsafe abortions and highest maternal mortality rates — including the highest number of maternal deaths per 100,000 abortions.

The new rules represent a radical expansion of earlier U.S. policy that cut assist-

[See Africa, A3]

JUDGE'S ORDER PAUSES STUDIO MERGER

The ruling grants a California-led request to freeze Paramount-Warner Bros. deal.

By Meg James

Hollywood's biggest deal in decades is on hold.

On Monday, a federal judge temporarily blocked Paramount Skydance's efforts to complete its purchase of Warner Bros. Discovery, ruling that the proposed \$11-billion merger "raises serious questions" about whether the combination violates U.S. antitrust law.

District Judge Araceli Martínez-Olguín, based in Oakland, granted a request for a temporary restraining order from a coalition of 12 state attorneys general, led by California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta, to freeze the deal while the court delves more closely into its effect on markets.

The order pauses the deal for 14 days. Martínez-Olguín's ruling sets up a showdown for Aug. 3, when she considers a motion for a preliminary injunction — which, if granted, could tie up the deal for months in advance of a trial.

"This is a critical first win in our case to ensure this megamerger never sees the light of day," Bonta said in a statement. "History tells the tale of what happens when a few people have great power over markets that are central to Americans' lives: fewer opportunities for more people, worse products and services for all people."

Two century-old film studios — with rights to Harry Potter, Batman, Scooby-Doo, "Top Gun," "Ted Lasso" and "Game of Thrones" — would be combined, and HBO, CNN and HGTV would come under new ownership.

"The judge basically said, 'Look, let's not race to the finish line here,'" Eric Talley, a Columbia Law School professor, said in an interview. "At the end of the day, maybe this thing gets signed off on, but I think the AGs are going to be given a fair chance to bring their claims forward."

The ruling dealt a blow to tech scion David Ellison's efforts to quickly finalize his massive merger, which has the support of President Trump. Ellison wants to complete the deal by Sep-

[See Merger, A11]